soap. There are mainly, two steps to be followed in this process.

i) Saponification of oil:

The oil, which is used in this process, is taken in an iron tank (kettle). The alkaline solution (10%) is added into the kettle, a little in excess. The mixture is boiled by passing steam through it. The oil gets hydrolysed after several hours of boiling. This process is called Saponification

ii) Salting out of soap:

Common salt is then added to the boiling mixture. Soap is finally precipitated in the tank. After several hours the soap rises to the top of the liquid as a 'curdy mass'. The neat soap is taken off from the top. It is then allowed to cool down.

Effect of hard water on soap

Hard water contains calcium and magnesium ions (Ca^{2+} and Mg^{2+}) that limit the cleaning action of soap. When combined with soap, hard water develops a thin layer (precipitates of the metal ions) called 'scum', which leaves a deposit on the clothes or skin and does not easily rinse away. Over time, this can lead to the deterioration of the fabric and eventually ruin the clothes. On the other hand, detergents are made with chemicals that are not affected by hard water.



Why ordinary soap is not suitable for using with hard water?

Ordinary soaps when treated with hard water, precipitate as salts of calcium and magnesium. **They appear at the surface of the cloth as sticky grey scum.** Thus, the soaps cannot be used conveniently in hard water.

11.9.2 Detergents

Development of synthetic detergents is a big achievement in the field of cleansing. These soaps possess the desirable properties of ordinary soaps and also can be used with hard water and in acidic solutions. These are salts of sulphonic acids or alkyl hydrogen sulphates in comparison to soap, which are salts of carboxylic acids. The detergents do not form precipitates with Ca^{2+} and Mg^{2+} present in hard water. So, the cleansing action of detergents is better than that of soaps.

Preparation of detergents

Detergents are prepared by adding sulphuric acid to the processed hydrocarbon obtained from petroleum. This chemical reaction result in the formation of molecules similar to the fatty acid in soap. Then, an alkali is added to the mixture to produce the 'surfactant molecules', which do not bond with the minerals present in the hard water, thus preventing the formation of their precipitates.

In addition to a 'surfactant', the modern detergent contains several other ingredients. They are listed as follows:

i) Sodium silicate, which prevents the corrosion and ensures that the detergent does not damage the washing machine.

ii) Fluorescent whitening agents that give a glow to the clothes.

iii) Oxygen bleaches, such as 'sodium perborate', enable the removal of certain stains from the cloth.

iv) Sodium sulphate is added to prevent the caking of the detergent powder.

v) Enzymes are added to break down some stains caused by biological substances like blood and vegetable juice.

vi) Certain chemicals that give out a pleasant smell are also added to make the clothes fragrant after they are washed with detergents.

11.9.3 Cleansing action of soap

A soap molecule contains two chemically distinct parts that interact differently with

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